Places Review App — Feature Brief & Brainstorm

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The idea

A personal map of every place you've actually been, each pin carrying your own short review, that you share with friends as one link. The pitch: **"Your friends' honest opinions, on a map, for any kind of place."**

The gap it fills: Google Maps reviews come from strangers, and your friends' recommendations are buried in WhatsApp chats and Instagram saves. You become the person friends ask "where should I go?" — and the answer is your map.

Positioning in one line: **any place, not just food; friends, not strangers; proof you were there, not just a wishlist.**

Core motto: sync your phone contacts, instantly see which of them are on the app, and open their map to see every restaurant and place they've been.

Platform: a native **iPhone app first (iOS only)**. Android comes later. The only web part is a small share page, so friends who don't have the app yet can open a shared map link.

What platrr does — and why it's not the same app

Platrr overlaps with your idea but is narrower and more curated. It is a café index for one city (Ahmedabad), logged dish by dish, with no paid placements.

What it has:

- **Dish-level logging** — rate a specific dish out of 5, tied to a verified visit.
- **Follow "palates"** — follow people whose taste you trust, not generic profiles.
- **Mood filters** — browse cafés by Calm, Quiet, Near me, Unvisited.
- **Taste Rooms** — community feeds: new dishes, recommendations, polls, photo recaps.
- **Tables** — users host meetups at a café (dish hunt, espresso hour) and others join seats.
- **City Council** — a small group of verified locals curates which cafés get in; users nominate new ones.

Where you differ:

	Platrr	Your app
Scope	Cafés only, one city	Any place, anywhere — cafés, treks, temples, hostels, viewpoints
Who adds places	Council curates; users nominate	Anyone adds any place
Social model	Public community, follow strangers' palates	Friends-first, personal map you share
Core object	A dish	A visit to a place
Main use	Find the next café	Remember and share where you've been

Takeaway: borrow their **verified visit** and **mood filter** ideas, but don't copy the curated-city model. Your edge is breadth and the personal, shareable map.

What already exists

No single app combines "any place + friends' reviews + visit proof + travel memory". Each competitor nails one slice.

App	What it does well	Idea worth stealing
Beli	Ranked restaurant lists, friends' feed, Taste Profile, Match Score with friends	Rank by comparison ("better or worse than X?") instead of stars; friend-rating average; streaks and yearly goals
Mapstr	Personal map of saved places, tags, share link viewable in any browser	No-app-needed share link; import from Google Maps; private custom places; To try / Tried status
Corner	Personalized map, learns your taste	Paste an Instagram/TikTok link and it becomes a pin
Polarsteps	Auto-tracks trip route, travel stats, printed travel book	Scratch-map of where you've been; turn a trip into a physical book

App	What it does well	Idea worth stealing
Platrr	Dish-level logs, verified visits, hosted meetups	Verified visit badge; mood filters; group meetups at a place
Google Maps	Huge place database, Local Guides	Use its Places API for search, don't compete on data

Weak spots to exploit: Beli is food-only, and some users find its ranking inaccurate (source). Mapstr caps free users and charges for unlimited places, which reviewers complain about (source). None are built India-first.

MVP core features

Ship these first in the iPhone app. Everything else waits until 20 friends actually use it.

1. **Sign up and profile**
   - Phone number + OTP (required — it powers contact sync), plus **Sign in with Apple**. If you offer Google login, Apple's App Store rules require an equivalent private login option like Sign in with Apple.
   - Username becomes the share link (yourapp.in/bodhi).
   - Profile header: places visited, cities, top categories.
2. **Contact sync (the core feature)**
   - "Find friends from contacts" right after sign-up — see who's already on the app and open their map. Details in the Contact sync section.
3. **Add a place**
   - Search via Google Places, or "I'm here" using the iPhone's GPS, or drop a pin manually for places with no listing (a hidden waterfall, a roadside dhaba).
   - Category: food, café, stay, trek, viewpoint, temple, beach, shop, other.
4. **Write a review**
   - Rating, short text, up to 5 photos straight from the camera roll, date visited, who you went with.
   - Quick tags: worth it / skip it, budget (₹–₹₹₹₹), best time to go, "order this".
   - Status: Visited, Want to go, Not recommended.
5. **Your map**
   - Native map view and list view of all your pins, color-coded by category.

    - Filter by category, city, rating, year.
6. **Share**
    - Share sheet: send your map, a place, or a list to WhatsApp / Instagram.
    - The link opens in the app if installed, or on a simple web page with a "Get the app" button if not.
7. **Privacy controls**
    - Profile is Public, Contacts only (default), or Private; hide individual pins (home, workplace).

Social and sharing

- **Friends** — follow / friend requests; find friends from contacts.
- **Friends feed** — "Rahul visited Dzükou Valley, 5/5". Chronological, no algorithm.
- **Friend rating** — on any place, show the average of your friends' scores, not the public score.
- **"Who's been here?"** — open any place and see which friends visited and what they said.
- **Save from a friend** — one tap adds a friend's pin to your Want to go list.
- **Ask for recs** — post "Going to Shillong next week, suggestions?"; friends reply by tagging their pins.
- **Collaborative lists** — "Agartala food crawl", "Goa trip 2027" — several friends add places together.
- **Reactions and comments** on reviews; "Thanks, went there!" button that credits the friend.
- **Shareable story cards** — auto-generated Instagram story image for a review or a monthly recap.
- **Home screen widget** — an iOS widget showing friends' latest visits or "1 year ago you were here".

Contact sync — the core feature

This is the main hook, and being a native iPhone app makes it possible: iOS lets an app read the address book after one permission prompt — the same way WhatsApp and Truecaller find your friends.

iOS specifics

- Uses Apple's Contacts framework. You must add a usage description in `Info.plist` (`NSContactsUsageDescription`) explaining why — App Review rejects vague ones.
- Since iOS 18, users can grant **limited access** (only selected contacts) instead of all. Handle it: show matches from what they shared and an "Add more contacts" button.
- Ask for permission at the moment they tap "Find friends", not on first launch — acceptance is far higher with context.
- Apple's guidelines don't allow uploading contacts for unrelated purposes or building profiles of non-users; matching friends with consent is fine.

How it works

1. Every user signs up with a **verified phone number** (OTP). Without verified numbers, matching is unreliable and anyone could claim anyone's number.
2. User taps "Find friends" → app asks contacts permission → reads numbers on the phone.
3. App normalizes numbers to +91XXXXXXXXXX format and sends them to your server.
4. Server matches against registered users' numbers, returns the matches, and **discards the rest immediately**.
5. App shows "12 of your contacts are here" → tap a name → open their map and reviews.
6. Re-sync quietly when contacts change, and notify: "Rahul from your contacts just joined."

Privacy rules to build in from day one

- Explicit consent screen before reading contacts; explain what's sent and that non-users are not stored.
- Never store numbers of people who aren't users. Hashing alone isn't enough — phone numbers are guessable — so match and delete.
- Setting: "Let people who have my number find me" (on by default, can switch off).
- Profile visibility: Public, Contacts only, or Private. Contacts-only is the right default for this app.
- India's Digital Personal Data Protection Act applies: clear privacy policy, consent, and a way to delete account and data.

Growth loop for friends without the app

- Contacts not on the app show an **Invite** button that opens WhatsApp with your map link.
- When a friend installs from that link, you're auto-connected.

- Friends on Android can still view your map on the web share page until the Android app ships.

Unique ideas — things nobody else does well

The strongest bets are marked ★. Pick two or three as your hook; the rest is backlog.

Trust and proof

- ★ **Verified visit badge** — review counts as "verified" if a photo's EXIF location/time matches the place, or you checked in on-site via GPS. Friends can tell real visits from wishlist pins.
- **Review freshness** — every review shows "visited 3 weeks ago" vs "2 years ago"; old reviews fade on the map.
- **Revisit log** — visit the same place again and add a new entry; see how your rating changed over time ("was great in 2024, went downhill").

Smarter reviews

- ★ **Compare-to-rate** — instead of stars, ask "better or worse than X you already rated?" (Beli's trick, applied to all place types).
- **Context tags that actually help** — solo-friendly, safe for women at night, bike parking, network signal, washroom, wheelchair access, pet-friendly, good for work.
- **"One thing to know"** — a required one-liner per review: the single tip a friend needs ("go before 7am, parking fills up").
- **Voice reviews** — record 30 seconds after the visit; AI transcribes and drafts the written review.

Taste matching (fits your AI search background)

- ★ **Taste Match %** — how much a friend's ratings agree with yours. Trust the 85% friend more than the 40% one.
- **Natural-language search over friends' reviews** — "quiet café in Kolkata where friends said the coffee is good". Semantic search on review text, scoped to your network.
- **AI trip draft** — "2 days in Shillong" builds an itinerary only from places your friends rated 4+.

Memory and journaling

- ★ **Year in places** — a Spotify-Wrapped-style recap: places, km, new cities, top category, most-revisited spot.

- **Trips** — group visits into a trip with a route line on the map; share the trip as a story.
- **Scratch map** — states of India and countries fill in as you visit them.
- **On this day** — "1 year ago you were at Neermahal".
- **Printed travel book** — export a year or trip as a PDF / printed photo book.

Fresh angles

- ★ **Time capsule notes** — leave a note on a place that friends only see when they physically go there ("try the corner seat").
- **Blind recommendation** — a friend sends you a place without revealing it; it unlocks when you're within 1 km.
- **Hidden-gem score** — places many friends loved but with few Google reviews get a "gem" label.
- **Import from Google Maps** — pull in your saved lists and Google Takeout location history to backfill years of visits on day one.
- **Paste a reel link** — drop an Instagram reel URL and it becomes a Want to go pin.
- **Friend city guides** — "Bodhi's Agartala" as a curated, shareable guide for visiting friends.
- **Offline mode** — maps and saved reviews work in the hills with no network (useful for Northeast and Ladakh routes).

Gamification and retention

Keep it light — the goal is "come back after every outing", not an addictive feed.

- **Badges** — First 10 places, 5 states, Café hopper, Trekker, Night owl, Early riser.
- **Yearly goal** — "Visit 50 new places in 2027" with a progress ring.
- **Streaks** — weeks in a row with a new place logged.
- **Explorer level** — based on verified visits, not review count, so spam doesn't pay.
- **Friendly challenges** — "Who visits more Agartala cafés in November?" between friends.
- **Nudges that matter** — after you've been at a new place for 30+ minutes: "Rate it while it's fresh?"
- **Helpful credit** — "3 friends visited places because of you" is the strongest reason to keep reviewing.

Monetization

Don't monetize until people use it weekly. When you do, these fit without breaking trust:

Model	How it works	Watch out
Freemium (Pro)	Free core; Pro unlocks AI trip planner, year recap export, offline maps, unlimited photos	Never cap the number of places — that's Mapstr's most complained-about limit
Printed books	Year or trip as a printed photo book	Needs a print partner
Business pages	Places claim their page, reply to reviews, see visit stats	Never let them pay to rank higher — keep it like Platrr's no-paid-placement rule
Affiliate bookings	"Book a stay" links on hotels/hostels	Clearly labeled
Creator guides	Popular reviewers sell paid city guides	Later stage only

iPhone note: a Pro subscription sold inside the app must use Apple's in-app purchase. Apple keeps a commission — 15% if you enroll in its Small Business Program (under $1M yearly revenue).

Suggested tech stack

Build the iPhone app in **Flutter** — you already know it, and the same code becomes the Android app later at no extra effort. SwiftUI is the alternative if you want the most native iOS feel and never plan Android.

Layer	Choice	Why
iPhone app	Flutter (or SwiftUI)	Your existing skill; Android later from the same code
Build machine	A Mac with Xcode	Apple only allows iOS builds from macOS. No Mac → cloud builds (Codemagic) or a used Mac mini

Layer	Choice	Why
Backend	Supabase (Postgres + Auth + Storage), FastAPI for AI jobs	Phone OTP auth, row-level security for privacy rules, photo storage
Geo	PostGIS extension	"Places within 2 km", clustering pins, verified-visit distance checks
Map display	Google Maps SDK for iOS (`google_maps_flutter`) or Apple Maps	Both free with no usage limit in a native app
Place search	Google Places API, called from your backend	Best place coverage in India, incl. small towns
Contacts	Apple Contacts framework (`flutter_contacts`)	Reads numbers after permission; supports iOS 18 limited access
Location	Core Location	"I'm here" check-in and verified visits
Push notifications	Apple Push (APNs) via Firebase Cloud Messaging	Free
Share page	Tiny Next.js page on Cloudflare Pages	Opens shared links for people without the app; free hosting
Semantic search	pgvector inside Supabase	Natural-language search over friends' reviews

Core tables: `users`, `places` (shared, with geo point), `visits` (user × place × date — one row per visit, so revisits work), `reviews` (on a visit), `photos`, `follows`, `lists`, `list_items`. Keep **place** and **visit** separate from day one — it's what makes verified visits, revisits and trips possible later.

Google Maps — do you have to pay?

Short answer: as an iPhone app, showing maps is free with no limit. You only pay for place search, and that's free up to 35,000 lookups a month. You still need a Google Cloud billing account with a card.

Google has India-specific pricing: each API gets a large free monthly quota, and paid rates are up to 70% lower than global. It applies if your billing address is in India and most usage is in India (source).

What the app would use (India rates, per month) — price list:

What you use it for	Google API	Free per month	After that (per 1,000)
Map inside the iPhone app	Maps SDK for iOS	Unlimited	Free
Search box when adding a place	Autocomplete (session, followed by Place Details)	Unlimited	Free
Getting the place's name, address, location	Place Details Pro (name is a Pro field)	35,000	$5.10
"I'm here" — address from GPS	Geocoding	70,000	$1.50
Map image on the web share page / link preview	Static Maps	70,000	$0.60
Place photos from Google	Place Details Photos	7,000	$2.10

Alternative: Apple Maps (MapKit) is also free in a native iOS app and includes place search, but Google's place data for Indian cafés, dhabas and small towns is usually more complete.

Rough cost by users (assuming each user adds ~10 new places a month and you reuse places already in your database):

- 1,000 users → ~10,000 Place Details → **₹0**
- 3,000 users → ~30,000 → **₹0**
- 10,000 users → ~100,000 → ~~65,000 over the free quota →~~ **$330/month** (fewer if many users add the same places)

How to keep it near ₹0:

- Call Place Details only when a `place_id` isn't already in your database. When the second user adds the same café, reuse your record.
- Request only the fields you need (field masks) so calls stay in the cheapest SKU.
- Don't use Google place photos — users upload their own.

- Restrict the API key to your iOS bundle ID and backend, and set **budget alerts and daily quota caps** in Google Cloud Console.
- Follow Google's caching rules: `place_id` can be stored indefinitely; other fields have limits.

Where money goes — full cost breakdown

Prices in USD from the providers; rupee figures use roughly ₹88 = $1 and exclude 18% GST where applicable.

Item	What it's for	Free option	Paid when you need it	When to pay
Apple Developer Program	TestFlight beta for friends + App Store release	Run on your own iPhone from Xcode for free (app expires every 7 days)	$99/year (~₹8,700)	Before friends test it
Mac for building	Xcode only runs on macOS	Cloud builds (Codemagic free tier)	Used Mac mini ~₹35,000–50,000 (approx.)	Only if you don't have a Mac
Database + auth + storage — Supabase	Users, places, reviews, photos	Free: 500 MB DB, 1 GB files, 50k users; **pauses after 1 week idle**	Pro $25/mo (~₹2,200): 8 GB DB, 100 GB files, no pausing, daily backups	Public launch
Google Maps Platform	Place search; maps are free in-app	Free quotas above	Pay-per-use above quota	Card needed from day 1
Phone OTP SMS	Verified numbers for contact sync	—	~₹0.15–0.25 per OTP via MSG91 + DLT registration (source)	From first signup

Item	What it's for	Free option	Paid when you need it	When to pay
Domain (.in or .com)	Share links, privacy policy page	—	~₹700–1,200/year (approx.)	Before App Store submission
Share page hosting	Web page for shared links	Cloudflare Pages (free)	—	—
Push notifications	"Friend joined", nudges	Firebase Cloud Messaging → APNs is free	—	—
Email (receipts, alerts)	Transactional email	Free tiers (Resend, Brevo)	~$20/mo at scale (approx.)	Later
AI search + trip planner	Embeddings + LLM calls	pgvector inside Supabase	~₹300–1,500/mo at small scale (approx.)	Phase 3
Analytics, crash reports	PostHog, Firebase Crashlytics	Free tiers	—	—
Privacy policy / terms	Required by Apple + DPDP Act	Templates	~₹5,000–15,000 lawyer review (approx.)	Before App Store submission
Google Play account	Android app	—	$25 one-time (~₹2,200)	Only when Android starts

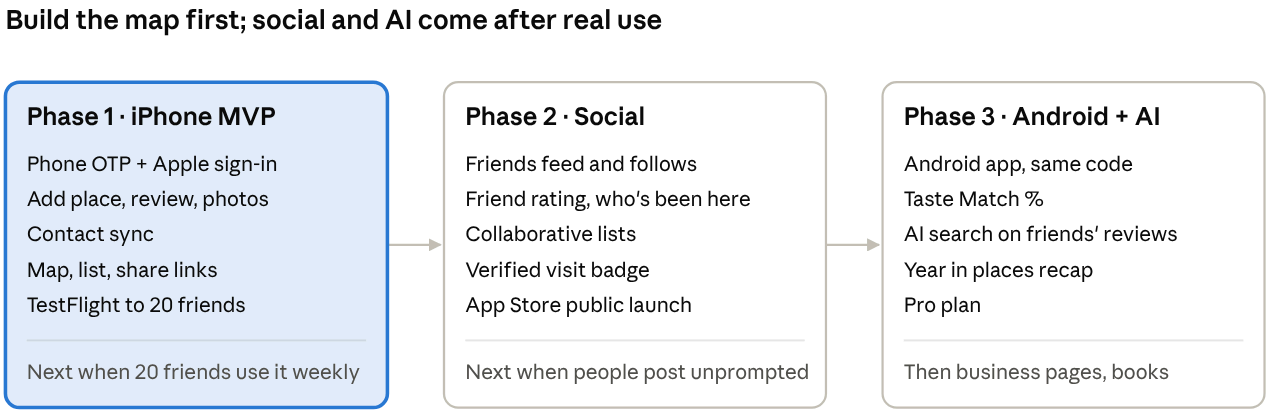
Minimum budget, first year (through Phase 3):

Plan	One-time / yearly	Monthly	First year total
Lean — you have a Mac, Supabase free until real users, templates for policy	~₹10,000 (Apple + domain)	~₹0–1,000 (OTP SMS)	**~₹12,000–20,000**

Plan	One-time / yearly	Monthly	First year total
Comfortable — Supabase Pro, AI features, lawyer-checked policy	~₹20,000	~₹4,000–5,000	**~₹65,000–80,000**
No Mac	Add a used Mac mini (~₹35,000–50,000) or use free cloud builds	—	—

Figures marked approx. are estimates, not quoted prices. Google Maps is assumed to stay within free quotas up to ~3,000 users. The one cost you can't avoid is Apple's $99/year — without it, friends can't install the app.

Roadmap and open questions



roadmap · 3 phases, each gated on real usage

iPhone first, Android in Phase 3. Each phase starts only when the one before has real users — a social feed with no friends on it is empty.

Open questions to decide early:

- [ ] Name and domain — something short that works as a verb ("just check my ___").
- [ ] Flutter or SwiftUI? Flutter if Android is coming within a year; SwiftUI only if you're staying iPhone-only.
- [ ] Google Places (better India coverage, free up to 35k lookups/month) or Apple Maps search (free, thinner in small towns)?
- [ ] Friends-only, or also public profiles anyone can follow?

- [ ] First 20 users: your college friends, a travel or biker group, or a city like Agartala?
- [ ] Do you have a Mac for Xcode builds, or will you use cloud builds?
- [ ] When to start Android — after how many iPhone users, or when friends on Android keep asking?

Sources

- Platrr homepage
- Beli on the App Store · Stanford Daily on Beli
- Mapstr on the App Store
- Corner on the App Store
- Polarsteps app listing